100

NON-NEGOTIABLE RULES FOR MEN

An evidence-based guide to body, mind, character, love, money and legacy

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100 Non-Negotiable Rules for Men

An evidence-based guide to body, mind, character, love, money and legacy

Compiled from published research on health, psychology, relationships, fatherhood, personal finance and habit formation.

About this book

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Important notice. This book is general education, not medical, psychological, legal or financial advice. Health screening ages, tax rules, products and laws differ between countries and change over time. Before changing your medication, exercise plan, diet or finances, or if you have symptoms or concerns, speak to a qualified professional.

About the evidence. The facts and figures in this book were gathered from public sources, listed by number in the Sources section at the end. Numbers in square brackets, such as [12], point to those sources. Where research is observational, the book says so; association is not the same as proof of cause. Several statistics come from the United States, the United Kingdom or Australia and may not match your country. Rules based on principle rather than data are described as such. Please verify anything important at the original source.

If you are struggling. If you are in distress or thinking about harming yourself, please contact local emergency services or a crisis line now, or speak to someone you trust. In India, Tele-MANAS (14416) offers free mental-health support; check the current number for your country.

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INTRODUCTION

Why These Rules, and How to Use Them

Most lists of rules for men are one person's opinion dressed up as law. This one tries to be different. Every chapter was built by starting with the research: the longest study of adult life ever conducted, decades of laboratory work on couples, global health guidelines, studies of fathers and children, and the basics of personal finance and habit formation. Where the evidence is strong, the rule says so. Where a rule rests on principle rather than data, it says that too.

The word 'non-negotiable' is deliberate. These are not suggestions for when life is calm. They are the standards that, if you hold them for years, tend to produce a body that works, a mind that is steady, a character others can trust, relationships that last, money that is secure and a life you are not ashamed of. Several of them are hard. None is complicated.

The big finding. The Harvard Study of Adult Development has followed 724 men since 1938. Its message, repeated by its directors, is that good relationships keep us happier and healthier, and that the men who were most satisfied in their relationships at 50 were the healthiest at 80 [12]. Money, status and fame did not predict a good old age. That is why a large part of this book is about people, not performance.

How the book is organised. There are ten chapters of ten rules each. The first half covers the person (Body, Mind, Character). The second covers the people around you (Love, Friendship, Family). The final half covers how you operate in the world (Money, Work, Discipline) and what you leave behind (Conduct and Legacy). Each rule has the same four parts: a short statement of why it matters, the evidence or reasoning behind it, and one concrete action you can take this week.

How to read it. You can read straight through, but you do not need to. Start with the chapter that hurts most. Do not try to change all 100 things at once.

Pick three rules, practise them for 90 days (the research suggests a new habit takes about two months on average, and often much longer [22][23]), then add three more. At the back there is a one-page checklist of all 100 rules to tick off over time.

A word on tone. This book is written for men, but nothing in it asks you to be harder, colder or louder. Nearly every rule asks for the opposite: more honesty, more presence, more restraint, more asking for help. That is not softness. It is what strength looks like when it is aimed at something worth protecting.

CHAPTER 1

The Body

Health is the foundation every other rule stands on

A man who cannot trust his body cannot fully show up for his family, his work or his friends. The data on men's health is blunt: in the United States men live roughly five years less than women, and researchers say a large part of that gap comes from men ignoring routine care, skipping screenings and delaying visits to the doctor [7]. The rules in this chapter are not about looking a certain way. They are about staying capable, for as long as possible. Most of them cost little money and a modest amount of time. What they demand is consistency.

RULE 1

Move your body every single week

WHY IT MATTERS

Physical activity is the closest thing medicine has to a miracle drug, and it is free. It lowers the risk of heart disease, supports mental health, protects your joints and keeps you independent in old age. The rule is not 'look athletic'; the rule is 'never let a week pass without deliberate effort'.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The World Health Organization's 2020 guidelines say all adults should do 150 to 300 minutes of moderate-intensity activity, or 75 to 150 minutes of vigorous activity, or an equivalent mix, every week. The same guidelines stress that some activity is better than none, and that more is better for optimal health [1]. Brisk walking, cycling, swimming and sport all count.

> ***Do this:*** *Put it in your calendar today. A simple start: three 30-minute brisk walks and two short sessions of anything harder. Track it for 12 weeks.*

RULE 2

Lift something heavy at least twice a week

WHY IT MATTERS

From your thirties onward, muscle mass and bone density slowly decline unless you train them. Strength is not vanity; it is protection against falls, fractures, back pain and the loss of independence. Strong men recover faster from illness and injury.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The WHO guidelines recommend muscle-strengthening activity involving all major muscle groups on at least two days per week, for adults of every age [1]. This can be done with weights, resistance bands, bodyweight exercises such as push-ups, squats and rows, or heavy manual work, as long as the effort is real.

> ***Do this:*** *Learn four basic movements - a squat, a push, a pull and a hinge - and do them twice a week. If you are new, book one session with a qualified trainer to learn the form.*

RULE 3

Protect your sleep like an important appointment

WHY IT MATTERS

Sleep is when your body repairs tissue, consolidates memory and regulates mood and hormones. Men often treat sleeplessness as a badge of honour. The evidence says it is a slow leak in your health, your temper and your judgment.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

General guidance for adults is 7 to 9 hours a night, and poor sleep tends to worsen both mental and physical health problems [28]. A large US study reported by the World Economic Forum found that men with all five healthy sleep habits, which include sleeping seven to eight hours and not depending on sleep medication, had a life expectancy 4.7 years longer than men with none or only one, and were 30 percent less likely to die prematurely [3].

> ***Do this:*** *Fix a wake-up time and keep it, even on weekends. Cut caffeine in the afternoon, keep the bedroom dark and cool, and put the phone outside the bedroom.*

RULE 4

Know your numbers: blood pressure, cholesterol, blood sugar

WHY IT MATTERS

The most dangerous conditions in men's health - high blood pressure, raised cholesterol and high blood sugar - are often silent in their early stages. By the time you feel them, damage has been done to your heart, brain, kidneys and nerves.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Screening guidance from MedlinePlus says men should have blood pressure checked regularly (at least yearly from age 40), begin cholesterol screening between about age 20 and 35 depending on risk, and be screened for prediabetes and type 2 diabetes from the mid-thirties or forties onward, earlier with risk factors such as family history, high blood pressure or being overweight [5][6]. Exact ages vary by country and by guideline body.

> ***Do this:*** *Book a basic check this month. Write your three numbers in your phone's notes and update them every time you are tested.*

RULE 5

Keep a screening calendar for the cancers you can catch early

WHY IT MATTERS

Many cancers are far more treatable when found early. Screening is one of the few areas of medicine where a few hours of mild inconvenience can save years of life.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Guidelines commonly recommend colorectal cancer screening for men aged roughly 45 to 75 [5], and a conversation with a doctor about prostate cancer screening around age 50, or around 45 for men at higher risk such as those with a family history or of African descent [6]. For men aged 65 to 75 who have ever smoked, a one-time ultrasound screening for abdominal aortic aneurysm is recommended [4]. Screening advice differs between countries and changes over time, so use these as a starting point for a conversation, not as a final answer.

> ***Do this:*** *Ask your doctor: 'Given my age and family history, which screenings do I need and when?' Put the answers in your calendar with reminders.*

RULE 6

When something feels wrong, go. Do not wait.

WHY IT MATTERS

Men are notorious for waiting. A lump, blood in the stool, a persistent cough, chest discomfort, unexplained weight loss, a mole that changes - the pattern is the same: ignore it, hope it goes away, go late. That delay is a major reason the longevity gap exists.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Public-health commentary on the male-female life-expectancy gap, which was 5.4 years in the US in early 2020, notes that men take more risks and work in more hazardous jobs, but also that they skip routine screenings and doctor visits far more than women [7]. A review cited by El Camino Health also found that

men who have not experienced a serious health event are unlikely to have a regular health provider or an annual wellness exam [28].

> ***Do this:*** *Adopt a personal rule: any symptom that lasts more than two weeks, or that frightens you, gets examined. Find a regular doctor now, before you need one.*

RULE 7

Treat alcohol as a risk, not a reward

WHY IT MATTERS

Alcohol is socially normal and chemically toxic. Many men use it to unwind, to bond or to numb stress. It is a poor tool for all three. The honest question is not 'how much can I get away with?' but 'what is this costing me?'

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

In 2023 the World Health Organization stated in The Lancet Public Health that there is no safe level of alcohol consumption that does not affect health: the risk starts from the first drop, and alcohol is a Group 1 carcinogen, the same top category as tobacco and asbestos [2]. In 2016, alcohol accounted for 6.8 percent of male deaths worldwide, compared with 2.2 percent of female deaths, according to a global analysis covering 195 countries [42]. Some statisticians point out that 'no safe level' does not mean 'must be zero', as with driving, but the direction of the evidence is clear: less is better.

> ***Do this:*** *Set a firm weekly limit and several alcohol-free days. If you cannot keep to a limit you set, that is information. Talk to a doctor.*

RULE 8

Do not use tobacco in any form

WHY IT MATTERS

There is no negotiation to be had here. Tobacco is a leading cause of preventable disease and early death, and nicotine dependence is built to keep you using it. Quitting at any age brings benefits, and the earlier the better.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The International Agency for Research on Cancer places tobacco alongside alcohol, asbestos and radiation in its highest category of cancer-causing agents (Group 1) [2]. Smoking is also a major risk factor for heart disease, stroke and lung disease, and it is the reason doctors recommend extra screening such as the aortic aneurysm check for men who have ever smoked [4].

> ***Do this:*** *If you use tobacco, make quitting a project: set a date, ask your doctor about cessation medication and counselling, and tell your family so they can support you.*

RULE 9

Eat for the long game

WHY IT MATTERS

You do not need a perfect diet; you need a boringly decent one, eaten for decades. Food decides your weight, blood pressure, cholesterol, energy and mood. Fad diets fail because they cannot be sustained for years.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

A long-term Harvard study, as summarised in a men's health feature, identified eating healthily and exercising regularly among a small set of core behaviours that dramatically extend life expectancy [41]. In practice that means mostly whole foods: vegetables, fruit, pulses, whole grains, nuts, fish or lean protein, and fewer ultra-processed snacks, sugary drinks and fried foods.

> ***Do this:*** *Make three swaps this week: sugary drinks to water, a processed snack to fruit or nuts, and one meal a day built around vegetables and protein. Cook at home more often than you eat out.*

RULE 10

Sit less, and make movement part of your day

WHY IT MATTERS

A one-hour gym session cannot fully undo ten hours of sitting. Desk work, long commutes and screens have made modern men more sedentary than any generation before. The fix is not heroic; it is frequent small movements.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The WHO 2020 guidelines added, for the first time, an explicit recommendation to reduce sedentary behaviour, and the lead of the guideline group emphasised that all movement counts - climbing stairs and even household cleaning [1]. Standing up every 30 to 60 minutes, walking while on calls and taking stairs are all supported by this principle.

> ***Do this:*** *Set a timer to stand up and move for two minutes every hour of desk work. Walk after meals.*

CHAPTER 2

The Mind

Emotional strength is a skill, not a personality trait

Men are raised to believe that strength means silence. The research says otherwise. In the United States in 2022, nearly four in five deaths by suicide were men [9]. In England and Wales the male suicide rate is around three times the female rate [11]. In an Australian national study of male health, up to 25 percent of men had been diagnosed with a mental health disorder in their lifetime, yet only about a quarter said they would seek help from a mental health professional if they had a personal or emotional problem [8]. The gap between suffering and help is the problem. This chapter is about closing it.

RULE 11

Treat your mind with the same seriousness as your body

WHY IT MATTERS

You would not ignore a broken leg and call it weakness to see a doctor. A mind under sustained strain is also an injury, and it responds to treatment. Depression, anxiety, burnout and trauma are health conditions, not character flaws.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The Ten to Men longitudinal study of Australian men found that up to 15 percent experienced a mental disorder in any given 12-month period [8]. These are not rare cases; they describe a large share of the men around you, including capable, high-functioning ones. Researchers also note that wealthy, professionally successful men are not protected from isolation or depression by their status [11].

> ***Do this:*** *Once a year, take stock honestly: sleep, mood, energy, interest in things you used to enjoy. If two or more are off for more than two weeks, speak to a doctor or counsellor.*

RULE 12

Ask for help early, not as a last resort

WHY IT MATTERS

Most men ask for help only after things have collapsed. By then the problem is larger, the options fewer and the damage to relationships greater. Early help is cheaper, quicker and far more effective.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

In the Australian study, researchers listed cost, wait times, stigma and the fear that asking for help will be seen as weakness among the barriers keeping men from services [8]. A survey of 2,000 men by Mentoring Men found that the biggest barrier was not unwillingness but not knowing where to turn: many men 'push through on their own' [29]. Knowing where to go in advance removes that barrier.

> ***Do this:*** *Find a doctor, a counsellor and one crisis line before you need them, and save the numbers. In India, the government's Tele-MANAS service (14416) offers free, confidential mental-health support; check the current number for your country. If you are ever in immediate danger, contact local emergency services.*

RULE 13

Learn the vocabulary of your own feelings

WHY IT MATTERS

Many men can describe a problem in detail but cannot name the feeling underneath it. 'I'm fine' becomes the default answer for anger, grief, fear, shame and exhaustion alike. If you cannot name it, you cannot manage it, and you cannot explain it to anyone who could help.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Researchers at King's College London found that men's loneliness is often misunderstood because it is expressed sideways, through withdrawal, irritability, drinking more, or a kind of surface functioning that hides deep isolation [11]. Naming the underlying feeling - lonely, ashamed, overwhelmed, afraid - is the first step of emotional regulation.

> ***Do this:*** *Three times a week, finish this sentence in a notebook: 'What I am actually feeling is ___ because ___.' Use a more specific word than 'stressed' or 'fine'.*

RULE 14

Take responsibility for your anger

WHY IT MATTERS

Anger is a normal emotion; what you do with it is your responsibility. Unmanaged anger damages marriages, destroys careers, frightens children and sometimes ends in violence or legal trouble. 'That is just how I am' is not an explanation; it is an excuse.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

A systematic review of nine randomised clinical trials found that cognitive-behavioural therapy, especially psychoeducation and cognitive restructuring, was the most commonly used and effective approach to controlling anger [21]. Other empirically supported methods include relaxation training and skill-building. Anger problems are treatable.

> ***Do this:*** *Learn your early warning signs (tight jaw, heat, racing heart). When you notice them, use a time-out: say 'I need 20 minutes', leave the room, breathe slowly, and return to finish the conversation calmly. If outbursts continue, see a therapist trained in CBT for anger.*

RULE 15

Pause before you react

WHY IT MATTERS

Between a trigger and a response there is a gap. The man who learns to widen that gap controls his relationships, his money and his reputation. The man who cannot lives at the mercy of every provocation, insult and bad mood.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Robert Waldinger and Marc Schulz, directors of the Harvard Study of Adult Development, advise striving for 'reflective' rather than 'reflexive' responses to difficult situations, particularly in close relationships [13]. A reflective response begins with a pause, a breath and a question: 'What am I actually trying to achieve here?'

> ***Do this:*** *Adopt a personal rule for any heated message or moment: wait ten minutes, or sleep on it, before answering. Never send an angry email or text the same hour you write it.*

RULE 16

Manage stress on purpose before it manages you

WHY IT MATTERS

Chronic stress does not stay in the mind. It shows up as poor sleep, weight gain, poor food choices, irritability, high blood pressure and eventually illness. Most men only notice it when something breaks.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Health practitioners note that unmanaged stress can lead to weight gain, unhealthy eating habits, depression and even chronic illness [28]. The practices with the best support are the dull ones: regular exercise, enough sleep, relaxation techniques such as slow breathing, and time with people you care about [40].

> ***Do this:*** *Pick one daily stress valve - a walk, ten minutes of slow breathing, a call with a friend - and treat it as non-negotiable. Reduce the stressor too: say no to one commitment this month.*

RULE 17

Do not numb it. Face it.

WHY IT MATTERS

Alcohol, endless scrolling, pornography, gambling, workaholism and constant busyness all do the same thing: they postpone feeling. The feeling does not go away. It compounds, and the numbing habit becomes its own problem.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Research on male loneliness describes withdrawal, irritability and increased drinking as common ways men cope with distress [11], and a meta-analysis found moderate positive links between loneliness and every mental-health symptom measured in men, including depression, anxiety and suicidal thoughts [10]. Avoidance feeds the very symptoms it is meant to relieve.

> ***Do this:*** *Notice what you reach for when you feel low or anxious. For the next 30 days, replace one numbing habit with one action: a walk, a call or writing down what is bothering you.*

RULE 18

Build a sense of purpose that does not depend on a job title

WHY IT MATTERS

Men often anchor their identity in work. When work ends through retirement, redundancy or illness, the identity collapses. A durable sense of purpose comes from several sources: people you serve, skills you build, causes you care about and responsibilities you keep.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Health writers summarising longevity research report that a strong sense of purpose is associated with better physical and mental health and longer, fuller lives [40]. The Harvard Study of Adult Development also found that men who defined their lives by their relationships were among the happiest participants, while a successful lawyer who staked everything on his career never found a path to joy [13].

> ***Do this:*** *Write down the three roles that matter most to you apart from work, for example son, father, friend or mentor. Decide one weekly action for each.*

RULE 19

Take loneliness seriously. It is a health risk.

WHY IT MATTERS

Loneliness is not a mood to be waited out. It is a risk factor for depression, poor sleep, heart disease and suicide. Men are particularly vulnerable because their social lives often shrink after thirty and revolve around a partner or coworkers.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The Harvard Study of Adult Development concluded that loneliness is toxic to health, and that people who were most satisfied in their relationships at 50 were the healthiest at 80 [12]. A meta-analysis found moderate associations between loneliness and mental-health problems in men [10]. Not all findings are alarming: a 2025 Pew study found little difference in reported loneliness between men and women, but men are less likely to turn to anyone when they struggle [11].

> ***Do this:*** *Ask yourself honestly: who could I call at 2 a.m.? If the answer is nobody or one person, treat building your circle as an urgent project (see Chapter 5).*

RULE 20

Protect your attention. Choose people over screens.

WHY IT MATTERS

Your attention is the raw material of your life. Social feeds, news cycles and endless video are designed to take it. A man who cannot concentrate cannot work deeply, listen to his children or think clearly about his own life.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Waldinger's practical advice from the Harvard study is simple: replace screen time with people time, and liven up a stale relationship by doing something new together [30]. The quality of your relationships, more than the quantity of your entertainment, predicts health and happiness in late life [12].

> ***Do this:*** *Set a daily limit on non-essential screen time and keep phones out of the bedroom and the dinner table. Use the time you recover to meet one person face to face each week.*

CHAPTER 3

Character

Who you are when it costs you something

Muscle, money and status can be lost. Character is the one asset that stays with you through every circumstance, and it is the main thing other people use to decide whether to trust you with their lives, their savings, their daughters and their secrets. Unlike the previous chapters, the rules here rest less on statistics and more on a simple observation from the research on relationships: trust is built or destroyed in small, ordinary moments, not in grand gestures. Psychologist John Gottman describes these as 'sliding door moments', everyday choices that either strengthen or crumble the foundation of trust [31]. Each rule below is a sliding door.

RULE 21

Keep your word, including the small promises

WHY IT MATTERS

A promise is a loan against your future self. Every time you keep one you build credit; every time you break one, even a trivial one, you spend it. Men who are reliable in small things are trusted with big things.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Gottman's work shows that long-term relationships are created through small words, small gestures and small acts, and that most relationships do not collapse from one blow-out but from many small betrayals of trust [31]. The same logic applies at work and in friendships: people judge you by whether the small commitments are met.

> ***Do this:*** *Stop making casual promises you do not intend to keep ('I'll call you', 'let's catch up'). If you promise, put it in your calendar. If you cannot deliver, say so early and renegotiate.*

RULE 22

Tell the truth, especially when it costs you

WHY IT MATTERS

Lies are expensive. They require memory, maintenance and an ever-growing wall of further lies. Truth, even when it is uncomfortable, is cheap in the long run and keeps your life simple.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Successful couples in Gottman's studies were not those without conflict but those who handled hard truths with respect and repaired afterwards [14]. Hiding bad news from a partner, a boss or a business associate almost always makes the eventual damage larger. Honesty is not the same as brutality: you can be truthful and kind at the same time.

> ***Do this:*** *Make a rule: no lies of convenience, no lies by omission about things that matter. When you must deliver bad news, say it plainly, early and without excuses.*

RULE 23

Own your mistakes. Do not blame.

WHY IT MATTERS

Blaming others feels safe and makes you powerless. If everything is someone else's fault, then nothing is within your power to change. Accepting responsibility is the beginning of every improvement.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Gottman identified defensiveness and blame as destructive communication patterns that, if unchanged, predict relationship failure with high accuracy [31]. Taking responsibility for your part, even if it is only twenty percent of the problem, disarms conflict and makes solutions possible.

> ***Do this:*** *When something goes wrong, ask first: 'What was my part?' Say it out loud: 'That was my mistake, and here is how I will fix it.'*

RULE 24

Apologise quickly and properly

WHY IT MATTERS

A good apology is short, specific and free of excuses. It names what you did, acknowledges the impact and states what you will change. A bad apology says 'sorry if you were offended' and makes things worse.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The Gottmans found that the couples who succeeded were the ones who made repairs, small gestures that de-escalate a conflict and restore connection [14]. Repair attempts matter more than avoiding mistakes, because everyone makes mistakes.

> ***Do this:*** *Use this structure: 'I am sorry for ___. I can see it made you feel ___. Next time I will ___.' Then stop talking. Do not add 'but'.*

RULE 25

Do the right thing when nobody is watching

WHY IT MATTERS

Integrity means your private behaviour matches your public image. The man who is polite to clients but cruel to waiters, honest at work but deceitful at home, or loyal in public but disloyal in private is not a man of integrity. He is an actor.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

No study can measure a man's integrity precisely, but the long-running Harvard Study of Adult Development, which followed 724 men for over eight decades, found that quality of relationships, which depends on trust, was the strongest predictor of who stayed happy and healthy as they aged [12][13]. Reputation is built by repeated private choices.

> ***Do this:*** *Pick one area where you routinely cut corners unseen (taxes, work effort, the way you speak about people behind their backs) and close that gap this month.*

RULE 26

Never use violence or intimidation

WHY IT MATTERS

A man's physical strength is a responsibility, not a licence. Violence, threats, shouting to dominate, destroying property and controlling behaviour inside a home are never acceptable, never 'just a heated moment', and are crimes in many places.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Anger management research shows that destructive anger is treatable, with cognitive-behavioural methods and relaxation training reducing aggression in controlled trials [21]. Gottman's research found that contempt, criticism, defensiveness and stonewalling are among the strongest predictors of a relationship ending [31]. Physical intimidation is far beyond those.

> ***Do this:*** *If you have ever hurt or frightened someone you love, seek professional help from a qualified counsellor or a programme for men who use violence. If you are on the receiving end, contact local services or emergency numbers.*

RULE 27

Treat consent and boundaries as absolute

WHY IT MATTERS

'No' means no, and silence is not yes. Respecting another person's boundaries, sexual, emotional or physical, is the minimum standard of decency. It is also the basis for any relationship worth having.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Couples that last, as Gottman's research and decades of clinical work show, are built on respect and emotional attunement. He reports that emotionally intelligent husbands who make 'maps of their wives' psychological worlds' are the key factor in successful marriages [16]. Consent is the simplest form of that attunement.

> ***Do this:*** *Ask clearly, listen to the answer, and accept it without sulking or pressure. Never touch, message or pursue someone who has told you to stop. Never act with someone who is intoxicated or unable to freely agree.*

RULE 28

Be courteous to people who can do nothing for you

WHY IT MATTERS

How you treat waiters, drivers, cleaners, junior colleagues and strangers is the clearest signal of your real character. Many powerful men are charming upward and contemptuous downward. Do not be one of them.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Gottman's studies show that small, everyday positive gestures, which he calls bids for connection, build the trust that holds relationships together [14]. A habit of respect, once learned, is practised in every setting, and people notice it.

> ***Do this:*** *For one week, thank everyone who serves you, learn names, make eye contact, and never raise your voice at someone who cannot answer back.*

RULE 29

Keep confidences

WHY IT MATTERS

People confide in the man who has never betrayed one. If you gossip, you teach everyone around you that nothing they tell you is safe, and your circle will quietly shrink.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Loneliness research notes that men are less likely to confide in friends than women are [11]. When a man does confide, a betrayed confidence confirms the belief that it is unsafe to be open, which deepens isolation. Being a safe person is one of the most valuable things you can offer.

> ***Do this:*** *Adopt this rule: if someone tells you something in confidence, it stops with you unless a life is at risk. Do not even share it with your spouse without permission.*

RULE 30

Choose humility over ego

WHY IT MATTERS

Ego protects your image and costs you your growth. The man who cannot be corrected stops learning, loses good advisers and repeats his mistakes. Humility is not weakness; it is the willingness to see yourself accurately.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Research on deliberate practice, the process by which people become expert, shows that improvement depends on seeking feedback and focusing on weaknesses, which requires accepting that you are not yet good [24]. Ego blocks that process.

> ***Do this:*** *Ask one trusted person each month: 'What is one thing I do that holds me back?' Thank them, do not argue, and act on what you hear.*

CHAPTER 4

Love and Partnership

What the science of lasting relationships actually says

If there is one finding that runs through the longest studies of adult life, it is that the quality of your close relationships predicts your health and happiness better than your wealth, your career or your fame. The Harvard Study of Adult Development, which has followed 724 men since 1938, found that the men most satisfied in their relationships at age 50 were the healthiest at 80, while living in high-conflict relationships was bad for health [12]. Psychologist John Gottman has spent decades studying couples in a laboratory setting, and says he can predict with high accuracy which will stay together [31]. The rules below translate that research into behaviour. They are written for men in committed relationships but most apply to any close bond.

RULE 31

Invest in the relationship every day. It does not maintain itself.

WHY IT MATTERS

Many men think of love as something you win and then keep by default. The research says the opposite: a relationship is more like a garden than a trophy. Without regular attention it decays.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Gottman puts it bluntly: if you do nothing to make things better in your marriage but also do nothing wrong, the marriage will still tend to get worse over time [31]. He also stresses that successful relationships are created through small words, small gestures and small acts, not through grand romantic events once a year [31].

> ***Do this:*** *Build three small daily habits: a real greeting and goodbye, one genuine compliment or thank-you, and ten minutes of undistracted conversation, phone away.*

RULE 32

Keep the five-to-one ratio

WHY IT MATTERS

How you behave during conflict matters more than how often you have it. Happy couples are not those who never argue; they are those whose positive moments far outweigh their negative ones, even in the middle of a fight.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

In Gottman's long-term studies, researchers recorded couples in conflict and coded each interaction as positive or negative. The couples who maintained a ratio of at least five positive interactions to every negative one during conflict were the ones still happily together years later [14]. The positives can be small: humour, affection, a show of understanding, an acknowledgement of the other's point of view.

> ***Do this:*** *During your next disagreement, deliberately add positives: 'I see why that upset you', 'you have a point', a touch on the arm. Count them if you must.*

RULE 33

Learn to make repairs

WHY IT MATTERS

Every couple argues. What separates lasting couples from failing ones is the ability to de-escalate and reconnect. Many men withdraw, sulk or wait for the other person to apologise first. Repair is a skill, and a man can learn it.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Julie Gottman has said that the couples who were successful a few years down the road were the ones who made repairs [14]. A repair can be as small as a joke, a softened tone, 'let me try that again', or 'can we take a break and come back?' The example John Gottman gives is of a man who, after an ugly fight, offers to share a piece of cheesecake [14]. Imperfect, but it is an attempt.

> ***Do this:*** *Agree on a repair phrase with your partner, such as 'Can we reset?', that either of you can use mid-argument without it being an admission of defeat.*

RULE 34

Turn toward your partner's bids for connection

WHY IT MATTERS

A 'bid' is any small attempt to get your attention: a comment about the day, a joke, a sigh, a touch. You can turn toward the bid, ignore it or turn against it. Each response is a deposit or a withdrawal in the emotional bank account.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The Gottmans describe bids for connection as central to how couples repair and reconnect, and say that the 'disasters' of relationships often fail at exactly this point [15]. The mundane moments of ordinary life, not holidays or anniversaries, are the building blocks of romance [31].

> ***Do this:*** *When your partner speaks to you, put down the phone, turn your body toward them and respond with at least one question or comment.*

RULE 35

Know that most conflicts will never be solved. Manage them.

WHY IT MATTERS

Many men approach disagreement as a problem to be solved and won. Research shows that most relationship conflicts are not solvable at all, because they come from fundamental differences in personality and values. The goal is to discuss them without damage.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Data from the Gottman Institute indicates that 69 percent of conflicts in relationships are perpetual, meaning they never go away [15]. The Gottmans' point is that a recurring fight does not have to be harmful if you know how to handle it with humour, respect and acceptance [15].

> ***Do this:*** *Identify your two or three perpetual problems. Stop trying to win them. Practise discussing them with curiosity: 'Help me understand what this means to you.'*

RULE 36

Know your partner's inner world

WHY IT MATTERS

Strong couples know each other deeply: worries, hopes, friends, stressors at work, small preferences, the story behind the old fears. It is a form of attention, and it requires you to ask and to remember.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Gottman reported that successful marriages were those in which emotionally intelligent husbands were 'making maps of their wives' psychological worlds', and that the key factor in a marriage working was often the man, even though women usually feel responsible for the relationship's success [16].

> ***Do this:*** *Once a week, ask three real questions about your partner's life ('What is stressing you at the moment?', 'What are you looking forward to?') and remember the answers.*

RULE 37

Never show contempt

WHY IT MATTERS

Contempt is eye-rolling, sneering, mockery, name-calling and the posture of superiority. It tells your partner they are beneath you. It is corrosive and it is among the best predictors of relationship breakdown.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Gottman identified four destructive communication patterns (criticism, contempt, defensiveness and stonewalling) that predict relationship failure with over 90 percent accuracy if the behaviour is not changed [31]. He regards contempt as the most damaging of the four. The antidote is cultivating a culture of appreciation and respect, and noticing what your partner does right.

> ***Do this:*** *If you catch yourself rolling your eyes or mocking, stop and replace it with a statement of your need: 'I feel ___ and I need ___.' Say one thing you appreciate about your partner every day.*

RULE 38

Be faithful, in action and in attention

WHY IT MATTERS

Infidelity usually begins long before the physical act, with emotional distance, secrecy and small compromises. It devastates trust, children and health, and rarely solves whatever pain it was meant to escape.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Gottman believes that affairs are usually a symptom of drifting apart, 'the deterioration of the friendship in the marriage', rather than the root cause of marital trouble [16]. That means the protection against infidelity is not just willpower; it is staying emotionally connected to your partner and being honest

when a marriage is struggling.

> ***Do this:*** *Set clear boundaries on private messaging and friendships. If you are unhappy, say so to your partner or a counsellor before you act in ways you cannot undo.*

RULE 39

Carry your share of the household, and see the work without being asked

WHY IT MATTERS

A relationship strains when one person carries the invisible load: planning, remembering, cleaning, organising. A man who says 'just tell me what to do' still leaves all the thinking with someone else.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The research on lasting relationships emphasises friendship, respect and shared responsibility, and Gottman's finding that small everyday acts matter more than grand gestures [31] applies directly: the dishes, the school forms and the grocery list are the small acts. Resentment grows when they are uneven.

> ***Do this:*** *Sit down together, list every task that keeps your household running, and divide them by ownership, not by favour. Own whole tasks from start to finish.*

RULE 40

Choose your partner with care. The choice shapes your life.

WHY IT MATTERS

Few decisions affect your health, wealth and happiness as much as who you commit to. Chemistry is real, but it is a poor guide to long-term compatibility. Character, values, kindness, how someone handles conflict and how they treat others matter more.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The Harvard Study found that living in conflict-ridden relationships is bad for your health, while warm, secure relationships are protective, and they do not need to be smooth all the time [12][32]. Gottman's team can predict many outcomes from how a couple handles conflict even early in a relationship [16].

> ***Do this:*** *Before committing, observe how the person handles disagreement, stress and disappointment. Talk openly about money, children, family and values. Take your time.*

CHAPTER 5

Friendship and Community

No man is meant to carry life alone

Friendship is not a luxury. After about thirty, many men's social lives quietly contract. Work and family absorb their time, old friends drift away, and the habit of making new ones fades. A survey of 3,750 Australian men by Beyond Blue found that when men hit 30, their social lives deteriorate, with a corresponding decline in support [25]. The cost is real. A US survey found friendship has been declining for both sexes since the 1990s, but more men report having fewer friends than women, and even when men do have friends they are less likely to confide in them [27]. The rules in this chapter treat friendship as what it is: a skill that needs practice and a habit that needs maintenance.

RULE 41

Treat friendship as a health priority

WHY IT MATTERS

Good friends do not just make life more enjoyable. They improve your odds of staying healthy and alive. Treating your social life as optional is like treating your diet as optional.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Dr Geoffrey Greif, author of 'Buddy System: Understanding Male Friendships', says men with more friendships live longer, healthier lives, and researchers at the University of Georgia found loneliness can be as damaging to mortality as smoking [25]. The Harvard Study of Adult Development reached the same conclusion from a different direction: social connection is good for you, and loneliness is toxic [12].

> ***Do this:*** *Give friendship the same status as exercise. Decide how many close friends you want, name them, and plan regular contact with each.*

RULE 42

Make the first move. Someone has to.

WHY IT MATTERS

Most men wait for others to call, then conclude nobody cares. In truth, most people are waiting for someone else to take the initiative. The man who initiates becomes the centre of a circle.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

A men's health commentator quoted in Men's Health Australia put it simply: 'Someone has to make the first move' [25]. A survey by Mentoring Men also found that men are generally open to support and connection, but many simply do not know where to turn or how to start, so they push through alone [29].

> ***Do this:*** *This week, text or call two people you have not spoken to in months. Say plainly: 'I was thinking about you. Want to grab a coffee or a walk?'*

RULE 43

Schedule friendship. Do not rely on 'we should catch up'.

WHY IT MATTERS

Spontaneous friendship works when you are twenty and live five minutes apart. Adult life requires structure. Friendships survive because they are put in the calendar and defended.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The Survey Center on American Life found that friendship has been declining in the US since the 1990s [27]. A practical observation, drawn from how many men's friendships actually survive (sports clubs, weekly games, regular trips), is that they are built around recurring activities. Shared activity gives men an easy way to be together without forcing conversation.

> ***Do this:*** *Set a recurring commitment: a weekly walk, a monthly dinner, a sports session or a standing call. Treat cancelling as a last resort.*

RULE 44

Be a man others can confide in, and confide in someone yourself

WHY IT MATTERS

Many men have people to do things with, but nobody to say real things to. A good friendship includes the moments when you say, 'I am struggling'. Without that, friendships stay shallow.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

A 2025 Pew Research Center study found that men are significantly less likely than women to turn to friends, family or professionals when they are struggling, and even when men have friends they are less likely to confide in them [11][27]. Research on loneliness links this reluctance with worse mental-health outcomes and with higher suicide rates among men [10][9].

> ***Do this:*** *Choose one friend and, once a month, share something real: a worry, a doubt, a failure. Respond to their openness with listening, not advice.*

RULE 45

Do not make your partner your only emotional lifeline

WHY IT MATTERS

Partners are precious but they are not a complete support system. Men who depend entirely on a wife or girlfriend for emotional support are vulnerable to collapse when the relationship ends, or when the partner is ill or overwhelmed.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Research cited in Australian counselling literature notes that men rely much more on their partners for social and emotional needs, and more on paid employment for friendship, whereas women have broader networks; among men aged 25 to 44 who live alone, support and friendship levels were found to be significantly lower than for men who live with others [26]. A single point of support is a single point of failure.

> ***Do this:*** *List the people who give you support outside your household and your workplace. If the list is short, put building it on your priorities for the year.*

RULE 46

Show up when a friend is in trouble

WHY IT MATTERS

The most reliable test of a friend is what they do when something goes wrong: a death, a divorce, a diagnosis, a job loss. Men often stay away because they do not know what to say. Showing up, even awkwardly, is almost always better than silence.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Studies show that men with low levels of social support are more likely to experience psychological distress, and that peer-to-peer connection complements formal health services [29]. Your presence is part of another man's safety net.

> ***Do this:*** *You do not have to fix it. Say, 'I do not know what to say, but I am here.' Offer a concrete action: a meal, a drive, a visit. Follow up two weeks later, when everyone else has gone quiet.*

RULE 47

Check on the friend who goes quiet

WHY IT MATTERS

Men in trouble often withdraw. The friend who stops replying, stops showing up or becomes unusually irritable may be in trouble. Do not take silence at face value.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

King's College London researchers found that men's loneliness is often expressed as withdrawal, irritability or drinking more [11]. Australian campaigners recommend that men meet their friends and check in on each other's wellbeing, because men often do not ask [29].

> ***Do this:*** *If a friend has gone quiet, contact them directly. Ask, 'How are you really doing?' and wait. If you are worried about their safety, do not leave it: involve family or professionals.*

RULE 48

Join something bigger than yourself

WHY IT MATTERS

A team, a club, a volunteer group, a religious or community organisation, a trade association: all of these give a man belonging, purpose and a ready-made network. They also give you a role outside work and home.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Emma George, director of the Western Sydney University Centre for Male Health, notes that initiatives that build social capital and foster peer-to-peer connection can complement traditional health services and improve reach and accessibility for men [29]. Strategies that reduce loneliness are broadly the same for all people: regular contact with friends and family, community involvement and physical activity [9].

> ***Do this:*** *Pick one group this month: a sports club, volunteering shift, hobby group or local association. Attend at least four times before deciding if it is for you.*

RULE 49

Build relationships across generations

WHY IT MATTERS

Younger men need mentors. Older men need purpose. Mentoring, formal or informal, strengthens both and prevents the isolation that grows when your social world is limited to your own age and role.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Mentoring Men, a free Australian service that connects men with trained local male mentors, reports from a survey of 2,000 men that the barrier is awareness rather than willingness: most men are open to support but do not know where to find it [29]. The Harvard study also found that relationships protect memory and health in older age [12].

> ***Do this:*** *Offer your experience to a younger man in your field or family. Also look for someone ten or twenty years older whose life you admire and ask them for an hour of their time.*

RULE 50

Prefer a few deep friendships over many shallow ones

WHY IT MATTERS

You do not need fifty friends. You need a few people who know you well, accept you and would be there at 2 a.m. Depth is built through time, honesty and reliability.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Waldinger stresses that the quality, not the quantity, of close relationships is what matters for health, and that people can be in a crowd and still be lonely [30][32]. Living in conflict-ridden relationships harms health, while warm, close ones protect it.

> ***Do this:*** *Identify your three to five closest relationships. Invest in them first. Be the kind of friend you want to have: reliable, honest, generous with time.*

CHAPTER 6

Fatherhood and Family

The job that outlives every other job

Whether you are a father, a future father, an uncle, a mentor or a son, family is where your character is tested every day and where your legacy is made. The research on fatherhood is consistent. A systematic review of longitudinal studies concluded that there is evidence for a positive influence of father engagement on children's social, behavioural and psychological outcomes, and urged professionals and policymakers to improve circumstances for involved fathering [17]. A US federal report on fathers' involvement notes that fathers' involvement has been associated with a range of positive outcomes for children [33]. The rules below are about what involvement actually looks like.

RULE 51

Be present. Showing up is the job.

WHY IT MATTERS

Children do not remember your salary; they remember whether you were there. For a child, a father's presence means being available, paying attention and being part of daily life, not just attending the big events.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The Acta Paediatrica review of longitudinal studies defined father involvement as accessibility, engagement and responsibility, and found that active, regular engagement with the child predicts a range of positive outcomes [17]. Where possible, take whatever paid parental leave your employer or country offers; the same review argues for policies such as paid leave for fathers to make involved fathering easier [17].

> ***Do this:*** *Block fixed time every week that belongs only to your children. Protect it from work and phones. Attend the school meetings, the doctor visits and the ordinary Tuesday evenings.*

RULE 52

Engage directly: play, read, talk, listen

WHY IT MATTERS

Being in the house is not the same as being with your child. Engagement means direct interaction: playing, reading, cooking together, helping with homework, talking about their day.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The same systematic review found that the form of engagement that has the strongest evidence is direct interaction with the child, and that no specific form of engagement has been shown to produce better outcomes than another [17]. In other words, it does not matter whether it is football, reading, fishing or building something. What matters is that you do it, regularly and with attention.

> ***Do this:*** *Pick an activity each child enjoys and make it your regular thing together. Put away your phone for the duration.*

RULE 53

Respect the child's mother, whatever the status of your relationship

WHY IT MATTERS

How you treat your children's mother is one of the most powerful lessons your children will ever receive about how men treat women, and about what a relationship looks like. It also decides how much access and influence you have.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The Fatherhood Research and Practice Network notes that the extent of father involvement is shaped by the quality of the mother-father relationship, whether the parents are still romantically involved and the father's desire to be involved [34]. Gottman's studies likewise show that how couples handle conflict affects their relationship, and children watch every moment of it [15].

> ***Do this:*** *Never insult your children's mother in front of them. Argue in private, repair in front of them, and keep disputes about the adults away from the children.*

RULE 54

Discipline with calm and consistency, never with rage

WHY IT MATTERS

Children need boundaries and consequences. They do not need a frightening father. Discipline carried out in anger teaches fear, not understanding, and damages the relationship you will need for the next twenty years.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Anger-management research supports the use of cognitive-behavioural methods and relaxation to reduce aggression [21]. Studies of father involvement have also found that fathers' involvement in school is associated with better academic competence in children but negatively associated with an authoritarian parenting style [35].

> ***Do this:*** *Make a rule: you never discipline when angry. Take a time-out first. State the rule, the consequence and the reason, then follow through without drama.*

RULE 55

Listen more than you lecture

WHY IT MATTERS

Many fathers talk at their children. Children who feel heard come to their father with problems; children who feel lectured stop talking. You want to be the person they call when something goes wrong, at fifteen, at twenty-five, at forty.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Waldinger and Schulz stress empathy and reflective responses as practical tools for strengthening relationships and for getting through disagreements [13]. Parents who listen create the conditions in which children can safely talk about school, friends and mistakes.

> ***Do this:*** *At least once a week, ask an open question ('What was the hardest part of your day?') and listen without correcting, fixing or judging. Reflect back what you heard.*

RULE 56

Model the man you want your children to become

WHY IT MATTERS

Children learn far more from what you do than from what you say. If you want a respectful son, be respectful. If you want a daughter who expects to be treated well, treat her mother and every woman well. If you want children who handle emotions, handle yours.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The systematic review concludes that father engagement positively influences children's social, behavioural and psychological outcomes [17], and advocates note that the benefits of involved fathers are not limited to childhood [37]. Fathers who are emotionally engaged give children a template for their own relationships [34].

> ***Do this:*** *Ask yourself weekly: 'If my child copied exactly how I handled stress, money, anger and people this week, would I be proud?' Fix one thing.*

RULE 57

Teach emotional skills to your sons, and respect to everyone

WHY IT MATTERS

Boys who are told not to cry grow into men who cannot ask for help. The statistics in Chapter 2 are partly the result of this teaching. Teach your sons that feelings are information, that asking for help is strength and that respect for girls and women is non-negotiable.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Men's help-seeking is low, with only about a quarter of Australian men saying they would seek professional help for emotional problems [8], and men are less likely to confide in friends [27]. The pattern is learned. A father who talks openly about his own feelings interrupts it.

> ***Do this:*** *Let your children see you name a feeling and handle it well: 'I'm frustrated right now, so I'm going to take a break.' Never say 'man up' or 'don't be a girl'.*

RULE 58

Share the load of raising children, and of running the home

WHY IT MATTERS

Raising children is a joint project. A father who leaves all the planning, scheduling and emotional work to the mother is a helper, not a parent. Fair sharing strengthens the marriage and deepens the bond with the children.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The review of father-involvement research includes responsibility, meaning taking charge of arrangements such as medical appointments and school, as one of the core components of involvement alongside accessibility and engagement [17]. Gottman's finding that small everyday acts hold relationships together applies here too [31].

> ***Do this:*** *Take full ownership of two or three child-related tasks permanently: for example the morning routine, school pick-ups, or doctor appointments. Do them without reminders.*

RULE 59

If you live apart from your children, stay involved anyway

WHY IT MATTERS

Divorce and separation do not end fatherhood. Your children need you more, not less. Consistency, reliability and absence of conflict are the gifts you can give, even when the arrangement is difficult.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

A US Department of Health and Human Services analysis of children in foster care found that children with highly involved non-resident fathers spent less time in care on average (21.4 months compared with 25.3 months), although the authors stress that causality cannot be determined [36]. The CDC's national report on fathers' involvement covers fathers who live apart from their children as well as those who live with them [33].

> ***Do this:*** *Keep every arrangement you make. Pay what you owe. Call at the agreed time. Do not use the children as messengers or as weapons.*

RULE 60

Honour your parents and care for them as they age

WHY IT MATTERS

The way you treat your parents teaches your children how they will be treated when you are old. Caring for ageing parents, with patience, time and money, is both a moral duty and one of the most meaningful things a man does.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The Harvard Study found that strong close relationships protect health and even memory in later life [12]. That is true for parents as well. Isolation in old age is a health risk, and adult children are often the main connection that older people have.

> ***Do this:*** *Call your parents or older relatives on a fixed schedule. Visit regularly. Help them with health appointments, finances and paperwork before they ask.*

CHAPTER 7

Money

Simple rules, practised for decades, beat clever tricks

Money problems are among the most common causes of stress, marital conflict and poor health. The good news is that sound personal finance is not complicated. University of Chicago professor Harold Pollack famously argued that the basic rules fit on a single index card, an idea he developed with journalist Helaine Olen in 'The Index Card' [19]. The rules below follow that spirit: a handful of boring habits, applied consistently. Note that several statistics quoted here come from the United States, and tax rules, products and interest rates differ by country. This chapter is general education, not personal financial advice; for decisions about your own situation, consult a qualified, fee-only financial adviser.

RULE 61

Spend less than you earn, always

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the first and the hardest rule. Every other financial rule depends on it. Income can rise and fall; the gap between what comes in and what goes out is what builds or destroys wealth.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Olen and Pollack's index card begins with this principle, and personal-finance commentators repeat it as rule number one: living within your means creates the flexibility to save, invest and plan without the threat of debt [20]. The Motley Fool's long-running guidance also stresses living below your means as part of reaching financial independence [38].

> ***Do this:*** *Track every expense for 60 days. Categorise it. Cut the three largest non-essential categories by a fixed amount and automate the savings.*

RULE 62

Pay yourself first: save 10 to 20 percent of income

WHY IT MATTERS

If you save what is left after spending, you will save nothing. Reverse the order: set the savings aside the day you are paid, and live on the remainder.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Guidance drawn from the index-card approach recommends saving 10 to 20 percent of income [20], and other personal-finance guidance suggests saving at least 10 percent for retirement [38]. The exact figure depends on your age and circumstances, but the principle of automatic, regular saving is universal.

> ***Do this:*** *Set up an automatic transfer on payday to a separate savings or investment account. Increase the percentage every time your income rises.*

RULE 63

Build an emergency fund before you do anything fancy

WHY IT MATTERS

Cars break, jobs end, people fall ill. Without a cash buffer, every shock becomes a debt. An emergency fund buys you freedom: you can leave a bad job, handle a medical bill and sleep at night.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

A Federal Reserve report cited by The Motley Fool found that 44 percent of Americans could not cover an unexpected $400 expense without borrowing or selling something; the same article suggests holding three to nine months of living expenses [18]. A Bankrate survey found that 61 percent of Americans could not cover a $1,000 emergency from savings [38]. Experts commonly suggest about six months of living costs, and say even a small starter fund puts you ahead of most people [38].

> ***Do this:*** *Start with one month of essential expenses in an easily accessible account, then build toward three to six months. Keep it separate from daily spending.*

RULE 64

Pay off high-interest debt as an investment

WHY IT MATTERS

Credit card and other high-interest debts are a guaranteed loss. Paying one off is equivalent to earning a risk-free return equal to the interest rate. No investment can reliably beat that.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Pollack and Olen illustrate this with the 'Rule of 72': if a credit card charges 24 percent interest, the debt doubles about every three years (72 divided by 24) even if you charge nothing more. They advise treating debt repayment as an investment earning that rate, guaranteed [19]. About 46 percent of US households carry credit card debt, with an average balance of roughly $15,654 among those who do [38].

> ***Do this:*** *List every debt with its interest rate. Pay the minimum on all and put every spare rupee or dollar on the highest-rate debt first. Do not take on new high-interest debt for consumption.*

RULE 65

Invest in low-cost, broad index funds

WHY IT MATTERS

Most people, including most professionals, cannot reliably beat the market. Broad index funds buy the whole market cheaply and require almost no skill. They are the closest thing to a default for long-term investors.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Personal-finance guidance consistently recommends low-fee index funds that track the broad market, noting that they are likely to outperform most managed stock mutual funds [18]. Pollack and Olen's index card includes the rule: buy inexpensive index funds [19].

> ***Do this:*** *Choose a broad, low-cost index fund available in your country. Invest a fixed amount every month regardless of market news, and avoid checking it daily.*

RULE 66

Watch the fees. They compound against you.

WHY IT MATTERS

A one percent fee looks small. Over decades it can consume a large share of your returns. You are charged fees all over your financial life: investment accounts, bank accounts, funds, insurance, retirement plans.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The Motley Fool example compares a typical managed stock fund with an annual fee of about 1.1 percent with an S&P 500 index fund that costs 0.1 percent or less. The article calls this rule powerful because the difference cascades over time [18]. The same logic applies to account fees and insurance-linked investment products.

> ***Do this:*** *Check the annual cost of every fund and account you hold. Move anything expensive to a cheaper equivalent unless there is a clear reason not to.*

RULE 67

Start early. Time does more than talent.

WHY IT MATTERS

Compounding rewards whoever starts first. A modest sum invested at twenty-five can outgrow a much larger sum invested at forty-five. The most expensive thing you can do is wait for the perfect moment.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The Rule of 72, mentioned above, works in both directions: money invested at a given rate doubles in roughly 72 divided by that rate years [19]. Because the effect is exponential, the earlier years matter most. Long-run financial success comes from applying a few solid principles consistently over a long period, rather than from clever shortcuts [39].

> ***Do this:*** *If you have not started, start this month with whatever amount you can. If you have started, raise the amount.*

RULE 68

Insure against catastrophe, not against inconvenience

WHY IT MATTERS

The purpose of insurance is to protect you from losses you could never absorb: a major illness, a death that leaves dependants without income, a disability. Without it, a single event can undo decades of saving.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Financial-planning guidance generally recommends health cover, term life cover if others depend on your income, and disability or accident protection where available. The emergency fund covers small shocks; insurance covers the large ones [18]. Products and rules differ widely by country.

> ***Do this:*** *Review your health and life cover this quarter. If anyone depends on your income, make sure a basic term life policy is in place. Avoid mixed insurance-and-investment products unless you fully understand the costs.*

RULE 69

Never chase get-rich-quick schemes or invest in what you do not understand

WHY IT MATTERS

Every year people lose savings to pyramid schemes, 'guaranteed' returns, crypto tips, forex signals and friends-of-friends. If someone promises high returns with low risk, they are selling something. The only people who reliably profit are the people who sell the dream.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Mainstream personal-finance guidance agrees that wealth comes from consistent saving and low-cost diversified investing rather than from shortcuts [39]. Pollack's index-card approach is designed precisely to make money simple so that people can avoid being drawn into complicated products [19].

> ***Do this:*** *Adopt a hard rule: never invest in anything you cannot explain in two sentences, and never move money under time pressure. Ask for the fees, the risk and how you exit.*

RULE 70

Talk about money openly with your partner, and keep records

WHY IT MATTERS

Money secrecy destroys trust faster than most people expect. Couples who share goals, debts, income and spending are better able to make decisions and avoid conflict. Records also protect you if something happens to you.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Relationship research shows that long-term stability depends on handling conflict well and building trust through small, honest acts [31]. Financial transparency is one of those acts. Hidden debts and secret spending are classic triggers of broken trust.

> ***Do this:*** *Hold a monthly 'money meeting' with your partner: review spending, savings, debts and goals. Keep a document listing all accounts, insurance policies and key contacts so that your family could find everything.*

CHAPTER 8

Work and Skill

Become useful, then become excellent

A career is not a ladder; it is a long process of becoming better at something that other people value. Job titles change, industries disappear and employers come and go, but a deep skill, a reputation for reliability and a network of people who trust you travel with you everywhere. The rules in this chapter draw on research into deliberate practice and habit formation, and on a simple observation: the men who do well over decades are rarely the most talented. They are the most consistent.

RULE 71

Master a craft

WHY IT MATTERS

Be known for something. Choose a skill that is valuable, difficult and worth a lifetime of practice, and aim to be among the best at it. Generalists are replaceable; people with deep expertise are not.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The research on expert performance by Anders Ericsson uses the term 'deliberate practice' to describe focused, structured, serious and detailed attempts to get better [22]. It differs from simply repeating what you already do. Continuous improvement over a career requires a sustainable plan for deliberate practice, and most people stop once they reach proficiency [24].

> ***Do this:*** *Name the one skill that would most increase your value in the next five years. Schedule at least three hours a week of focused practice on it, with feedback.*

RULE 72

Never stop learning

WHY IT MATTERS

Knowledge decays. Technologies change and professions evolve. The man who stops learning at thirty is obsolete at forty-five. Learning is a lifelong habit, not a phase of youth.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

A review of evidence-based learning practices points to a handful of techniques that work: retrieval practice (testing yourself), spaced repetition, interleaving different kinds of practice, and deliberate practice aimed at your weakest sub-skills, with growth-mindset interventions showing only small average effects [39]. Reading passively and re-reading notes are far less effective.

> ***Do this:*** *Spend 30 minutes a day on learning. Do not just read: write a summary from memory, or explain the idea to someone else.*

RULE 73

Be reliable. Finish what you start.

WHY IT MATTERS

Reliability is the most underrated professional quality. Talent is common; the person who delivers what he promised, when he promised it, is rare. Managers and clients reward reliability with trust and with opportunity.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Gottman's observation that trust is built in small everyday moments [31] applies at work as much as at home. Every deadline met and every message answered contributes to your reputation.

> ***Do this:*** *Under-promise and over-deliver. Keep a written list of commitments, and update the other person before a deadline slips, not after.*

RULE 74

Learn to communicate clearly, in writing and speech

WHY IT MATTERS

Clear communication multiplies every other skill. A man who can explain his ideas, write a short and clear email, give a presentation and negotiate calmly will outperform a more talented colleague who cannot.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Skill acquisition research stresses structured practice with feedback [22][24]. Writing and speaking are skills like any other: they improve through repeated attempts and corrections, not through reading about them.

> ***Do this:*** *Write a one-page summary of your week every Friday. Join a public speaking group or volunteer to present at work. Ask someone to critique your emails.*

RULE 75

Seek feedback and take it seriously

WHY IT MATTERS

Most people never learn how others see them, because those who see it will not say. Seek honest feedback from people you trust and respect, and treat it as data, not as an attack.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Deliberate practice depends on feedback that identifies specific weaknesses, so that practice can target them [24]. Without an external perspective, people tend to practise what they already do well.

> ***Do this:*** *Every quarter, ask a manager, peer or mentor: 'What is the one thing I should do more of, and the one thing I should stop?' Write down the answer and act on it.*

RULE 76

Know your market value and negotiate

WHY IT MATTERS

Many men are underpaid because they never ask. Pay and conditions are negotiated, not simply given. Negotiating your worth, without arrogance and with evidence, is a normal and respectable part of a career.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Personal-finance guidance emphasises that your income is the engine that funds saving and investing [20]. An extra raise early in a career compounds across decades through higher saving and higher subsequent offers.

> ***Do this:*** *Research salary ranges for your role, location and experience. Prepare three concrete achievements, ask for a specific number, and be willing to walk away politely.*

RULE 77

Build your network before you need it

WHY IT MATTERS

Most opportunities come through people who know and trust you. Networking is not collecting contacts; it is building real relationships, helping others and staying in touch.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The Harvard Study of Adult Development shows that the quality of relationships shapes wellbeing across life [12]. Professional relationships are one category of that. Mentoring services report that men are often willing to give and receive support but do not know how to begin [29].

> ***Do this:*** *Every month, contact two people in your field without asking for anything: share an article, congratulate a promotion, offer help. Accept invitations to meet.*

RULE 78

Do not let your job destroy your health or your family

WHY IT MATTERS

No job is worth your marriage, your health or your relationship with your children. Overwork reduces quality, creates mistakes and harms the people you love. Set limits and protect them.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Research summarised in this book links sleep, exercise and relationships to longevity and happiness [3][1][12]. The Harvard study found that a successful lawyer who staked his happiness on his career never found a path to joy [13].

> ***Do this:*** *Define your working hours and your non-negotiable family and health time. Take your holidays. If your job consistently requires more, raise it or change jobs.*

RULE 79

Do not let your job become your whole identity

WHY IT MATTERS

When a man is only his job, redundancy or retirement can feel like death. Cultivate a self that includes roles, interests and friendships beyond work.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Loneliness researchers note that many men rely on paid employment as their main source of social contact and support [26], which makes job loss or retirement a particular risk. Broader networks protect against that [29].

> ***Do this:*** *Keep at least two interests, two friendships and one community role that have nothing to do with your employer.*

RULE 80

Give credit generously and take blame honestly

WHY IT MATTERS

People remember who gave them credit and who took it. A team leader who shares praise and accepts responsibility for failures builds loyalty that no title can buy.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Gottman's research found that appreciation and responsibility strengthen relationships, whereas blame and defensiveness predict their failure [31]. The same behaviours work in teams.

> ***Do this:*** *When a project succeeds, name specific people publicly. When it fails, say first, 'That is on me,' and then focus on what to fix.*

CHAPTER 9

Discipline and Habits

Your life is the sum of what you repeat

Everything in this book can be reduced to one problem: how do you turn a good intention into a daily action that lasts? Willpower is not the answer. Research on deliberate practice concludes that willpower, motivation and good intentions are unlikely to be enough, and that to be sustained, the behaviour must become a habit, something that happens with little conscious effort or thought [24]. This chapter is about the machinery of habit and the practical rules of self-discipline that make the other ninety rules possible.

RULE 81

Build systems, not just motivation

WHY IT MATTERS

Motivation is a feeling, and feelings come and go. Systems, meaning schedules, cues, environments and routines, work on the days you do not feel like it, which is most days.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The deliberate-practice research states plainly that willpower and good intentions are unlikely to be sufficient and that behaviour must become a habit [24]. A habit has a cue that tells your brain to go into automatic mode, a routine and a reward [23].

> ***Do this:*** *For each important goal, decide: when, where, and what exactly? 'After I pour my morning coffee, I walk for twenty minutes.' Attach new behaviours to existing ones.*

RULE 82

Give a new habit at least two months, and expect it to take longer

WHY IT MATTERS

People quit too early because they believe habits form in 21 days. They do not. The popular 21-day idea comes from an old self-help book, not from research.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

A well-known study from University College London asked participants to try a new behaviour daily for 84 days. On average it took 66 days for the behaviour to become automatic, although the figure varied enormously by person and by behaviour, and in some cases was as long as 254 days [22][23]. In the same research, simple habits such as drinking a glass of water formed in about 59 days, eating a piece of fruit in about 65 days, and an exercise routine took around 91 days on average [22]. The researchers note the study had limitations, but the message holds: new behaviours take many repetitions.

> ***Do this:*** *Commit to one change for 90 days. Track it on a calendar. Do not judge the result before then.*

RULE 83

Start small enough that you cannot fail

WHY IT MATTERS

Ambitious plans collapse because they require too much too soon. A habit that takes two minutes is a habit you will do on your worst day. Once it is established, it can grow.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Habit formation depends on repetition more than on intensity. Because a habit is defined by occurring with little conscious effort [24], the goal in the early weeks is to make the behaviour easy enough to repeat daily. The average of 66 days for automaticity is measured in repetitions, not in effort [22].

> ***Do this:*** *Reduce any new habit to its smallest version: one push-up, one page, five minutes of study, a single sentence in a journal. Do it every day first, then increase.*

RULE 84

Do the hardest or most important thing first

WHY IT MATTERS

Your decision-making and focus are strongest early in the day and are depleted by interruptions, email and other people's agendas. If you give your best hours to trivia, your important work will always be postponed.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Experts on deliberate practice stress that high-quality, focused work is demanding and that most people avoid it once they reach basic competence [24]. Scheduling it first protects it from the day's distractions.

> ***Do this:*** *Decide tonight what the single most important task is tomorrow. Do it before checking messages or social media.*

RULE 85

Run a weekly review

WHY IT MATTERS

What is not reviewed is not improved. A short weekly review of your commitments, finances, health, relationships and goals prevents slow drift and lets you correct course early.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Evidence-based learning guidance recommends tracking a short set of measures, such as time on deliberate practice, and reviewing them regularly [39]. The same principle applies to your life as a whole.

> ***Do this:*** *Every Sunday, spend 30 minutes: What went well? What did I avoid? What is my one priority for each area next week? Put it in the calendar.*

RULE 86

Learn to say no

WHY IT MATTERS

Every yes is a no to something else. Men who cannot refuse become exhausted, resentful and unreliable. Boundaries are not selfish; they are the condition of being useful.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Overcommitment is a major source of the chronic stress that damages sleep, weight, mood and health [28]. Protecting time for the priorities in this book requires refusing some other things.

> ***Do this:*** *Practise a polite, firm refusal: 'Thank you for asking. I cannot take that on right now.' Do not over-explain and do not apologise repeatedly.*

RULE 87

Shape your environment so that good choices are easy

WHY IT MATTERS

Willpower works best when it is not needed. Put the gym bag by the door, keep fruit on the counter, remove snack food from the house and delete the apps you waste time on. Make the right thing the default.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Habit theory holds that cues in your environment trigger automatic behaviour [23]. If you remove or change the cue, you change the behaviour.

> ***Do this:*** *Identify one bad habit and one good habit. Change the environment this week so that the bad one takes five extra steps and the good one takes zero.*

RULE 88

Keep the promises you make to yourself

WHY IT MATTERS

Self-trust is built the same way as trust in others: through small kept promises. Every time you break a promise to yourself, such as 'I will wake at six', you teach yourself that your word means nothing.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Gottman's work on relationships shows that trust is built through small acts [31]. The same dynamic operates in your relationship with yourself: if you routinely ignore your own commitments, you lose the ability to rely on yourself.

> ***Do this:*** *Make fewer personal promises, and keep every one. If you must break one, notice, say why and adjust the plan.*

RULE 89

Rest deliberately. Recovery is part of discipline.

WHY IT MATTERS

Discipline is not constant strain. Athletes train hard and recover on purpose. Men who never rest burn out, damage their health and make worse decisions.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Sleep is central to recovery: the study discussed in Chapter 1 linked healthy sleep patterns with longer life expectancy in men [3]. Health guidance also lists relaxation, time with loved ones and exercise as healthy ways to manage stress [40].

> ***Do this:*** *Schedule at least one fully offline day or half-day each week, plus annual holidays. Sleep is not negotiable.*

RULE 90

When you fall off, restart immediately without drama

WHY IT MATTERS

Everyone misses days. What separates the people who succeed is not perfection but how quickly they resume. Self-criticism and 'what the hell' thinking turn a single slip into a collapse.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The habit research shows large variation in how long habits take, with some people needing many months [23]. Because progress is uneven, expecting perfection sets you up for discouragement. Resuming quickly is the skill.

> ***Do this:*** *Adopt a rule: if you miss one day, do the smallest version of the habit the next day. Do not try to 'make up' for it.*

CHAPTER 10

Conduct and Legacy

The practical skills and final questions of a well-lived life

The last chapter gathers the rules that do not fit neatly elsewhere: the practical competence a capable man should have, the daily conduct that others notice, and the preparation that protects the people who depend on you. It closes with the question that matters most, which is not 'what did I accumulate?' but 'whom did I love, and how well?' The Harvard Study of Adult Development, which followed men for more than eight decades, answered that question with unusual clarity: good relationships keep us happier and healthier [12].

RULE 91

Do not take stupid physical risks

WHY IT MATTERS

Men die and are injured far more often than women in accidents, in road crashes and through risky behaviour. A moment of bravado can end a life or leave a family permanently changed.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Public-health commentary notes that part of the longevity gap between men and women stems from men taking more risks and working in more hazardous fields [7]. A global analysis also found that alcohol accounted for 6.8 percent of male deaths in 2016, against 2.2 percent of female deaths [42].

> ***Do this:*** *Never drive after drinking or while looking at your phone. Always wear a seat belt and a helmet. Use protective gear at work. Walk away from fights.*

RULE 92

Learn first aid and basic emergency skills

WHY IT MATTERS

In a medical emergency, the first minutes matter most, and the person who knows what to do is usually a bystander. CPR, bleeding control and the recovery position save lives, including those of your family.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Heart disease and stroke are among the main health threats for men discussed in Chapter 1 [5]. Knowing how to respond to a cardiac arrest, a choking child or a serious injury is the practical counterpart to prevention.

> ***Do this:*** *Take a certified first-aid and CPR course this year and renew it every two years. Keep a first-aid kit at home and in the car.*

RULE 93

Be self-reliant: cook, clean, repair, manage your own affairs

WHY IT MATTERS

A man who cannot feed himself, wash his clothes or handle his own paperwork depends on others for basic survival. Competence in these basics builds confidence and respect, and it makes you a fair partner and a stronger roommate, husband and father.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Fair sharing of the household is a theme of the research on lasting relationships: small, everyday acts hold partnerships together [31]. Cooking at home also supports the dietary habits that matter for long-term health [41].

> ***Do this:*** *Learn to cook ten dependable meals. Learn to do laundry, basic repairs, a household budget and your own tax paperwork.*

RULE 94

Take care of your appearance and your surroundings

WHY IT MATTERS

How you present yourself signals how you treat yourself and others. This is not about fashion or expense. It is about cleanliness, fit, grooming, posture and a tidy environment, which affect how people respond to you and how you feel.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

There is little hard research on grooming itself, so treat this as a practical judgment rather than a statistic. One related point is well established: unmanaged stress and low mood can show up as neglect of food, sleep and self-care [28], so a sudden decline in how you look after yourself is worth noticing.

> ***Do this:*** *Keep a small set of clothes that fit well and are clean. Maintain a regular grooming routine and keep your home or room orderly. If you notice neglect creeping in, consider whether you are depressed.*

RULE 95

Listen more than you speak

WHY IT MATTERS

Most men talk to be heard and listen only to prepare their reply. A man who listens fully is rare, valued and trusted. It improves every relationship you have.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Waldinger and Schulz recommend consciously using empathy to connect with others and striving for reflective rather than reflexive responses [13]. Gottman found that the emotionally intelligent husbands who understand their partner's world are the key to marriages that succeed [16].

> ***Do this:*** *In your next three conversations, aim to speak for less than half the time. Ask follow-up questions. Wait two seconds after the other person finishes.*

RULE 96

Do not complain without offering a solution

WHY IT MATTERS

Constant complaint drains everyone around you and changes nothing. A man who raises a problem with a proposal is a leader; a man who only complains is a burden.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Gottman's research distinguishes between criticism, which attacks the person, and a gentle statement of a need, which invites a response [31]. A proposal turns frustration into constructive action.

> ***Do this:*** *Before you complain, ask: What exactly do I want to change? What is my proposal? Who can decide? Then say it once, clearly.*

RULE 97

Stand up for others. Do not tolerate cruelty.

WHY IT MATTERS

Silence in the face of bullying, harassment, abuse or injustice is a choice. Men who speak up, even at some cost, set the standard for the whole group. Courage is not the absence of fear but acting despite it.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

This rule rests on principle rather than a single study. Men's health researchers do note that peer-to-peer connection among men is a powerful tool for wellbeing [29], and the same peer influence can be used to set a decent standard of behaviour.

> ***Do this:*** *Decide in advance what you will say or do when you witness a joke, comment or action that crosses a line. Intervene calmly, support the target, and if necessary report it.*

RULE 98

Be generous with your time, attention and money

WHY IT MATTERS

Generosity makes life meaningful and builds bonds. Time and attention are often more valuable than money: visit the sick, help a friend move, mentor a young person, give to causes you believe in.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

A sense of purpose is associated with better physical and mental health [40], and the Harvard study found the happiest men were those who invested in people [12][13]. Generosity is one of the most direct ways of doing so.

> ***Do this:*** *Decide on a regular giving plan, even small: a percentage of income to charity and a few hours a month of time. Make it routine.*

RULE 99

Prepare for the worst: will, documents and a plan for your family

WHY IT MATTERS

Nobody likes thinking about their own death or disability. But if you have dependants, failing to prepare leaves them with confusion, conflict and financial hardship at the worst moment.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The emergency-fund and insurance rules in Chapter 7 are the financial side of this preparation [18]. A will, a nominee on every account and a list of important documents are the legal side.

> ***Do this:*** *This quarter: make a will, name nominees on bank, insurance and investment accounts, and write a one-page list of accounts, passwords (stored securely), insurance policies and key contacts. Tell your partner where it is.*

RULE 100

Review your life every year, and invest in the people who matter

WHY IT MATTERS

Most men never stop to ask whether their life matches their values. A yearly review, as serious as a business review, lets you correct course before regret sets in.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The Harvard Study of Adult Development found that the single most reliable path to a good life is investing in relationships: the men most satisfied in their relationships at 50 were healthiest at 80 [12]. Waldinger suggests replacing screen time with people time and doing something new with the people you love [30].

> ***Do this:*** *Each year, on a fixed date, ask: Where am I in each of the ten areas in this book? Whom am I neglecting? What one change would matter most? Write it down and make a plan.*

CONCLUSION

Begin Where You Are

You have now read 100 rules. You will not keep all of them, and nobody does. The point is not perfection. The point is direction: a life that, year after year, gets a little healthier, a little steadier, a little more honest and a little more connected than it was.

If the list feels overwhelming, use this order. First, protect the basics: sleep, movement, a doctor's visit and one honest conversation with someone you trust. Second, fix the one relationship that matters most. Third, put your money on autopilot: save first, clear expensive debt, build a small emergency fund. Everything else grows from these.

Every man in the studies quoted in this book was, at some point, twenty-five and unsure. The ones who aged well were not those who had no problems. They were the ones who kept showing up for the people in their lives and kept asking for help when they needed it [12][13]. You can start that today. Choose three rules from the checklist on the next pages, write the date, and begin.

THE 100-RULE CHECKLIST

Tick a rule when it has become a habit, not when you have merely read it.

1. The Body

[ ] **1.** Move your body every single week
[ ] **2.** Lift something heavy at least twice a week
[ ] **3.** Protect your sleep like an important appointment
[ ] **4.** Know your numbers: blood pressure, cholesterol, blood sugar
[ ] **5.** Keep a screening calendar for the cancers you can catch early
[ ] **6.** When something feels wrong, go. Do not wait.
[ ] **7.** Treat alcohol as a risk, not a reward
[ ] **8.** Do not use tobacco in any form
[ ] **9.** Eat for the long game
[ ] **10.** Sit less, and make movement part of your day

2. The Mind

[ ] **11.** Treat your mind with the same seriousness as your body
[ ] **12.** Ask for help early, not as a last resort
[ ] **13.** Learn the vocabulary of your own feelings
[ ] **14.** Take responsibility for your anger
[ ] **15.** Pause before you react
[ ] **16.** Manage stress on purpose before it manages you
[ ] **17.** Do not numb it. Face it.
[ ] **18.** Build a sense of purpose that does not depend on a job title
[ ] **19.** Take loneliness seriously. It is a health risk.
[ ] **20.** Protect your attention. Choose people over screens.

3. Character

[ ] **21.** Keep your word, including the small promises
[ ] **22.** Tell the truth, especially when it costs you
[ ] **23.** Own your mistakes. Do not blame.
[ ] **24.** Apologise quickly and properly
[ ] **25.** Do the right thing when nobody is watching
[ ] **26.** Never use violence or intimidation

[ ] **27.** Treat consent and boundaries as absolute

[ ] **28.** Be courteous to people who can do nothing for you

[ ] **29.** Keep confidences

[ ] **30.** Choose humility over ego

4. Love and Partnership

[ ] **31.** Invest in the relationship every day. It does not maintain itself.

[ ] **32.** Keep the five-to-one ratio

[ ] **33.** Learn to make repairs

[ ] **34.** Turn toward your partner's bids for connection

[ ] **35.** Know that most conflicts will never be solved. Manage them.

[ ] **36.** Know your partner's inner world

[ ] **37.** Never show contempt

[ ] **38.** Be faithful, in action and in attention

[ ] **39.** Carry your share of the household, and see the work without being asked

[ ] **40.** Choose your partner with care. The choice shapes your life.

5. Friendship and Community

[ ] **41.** Treat friendship as a health priority

[ ] **42.** Make the first move. Someone has to.

[ ] **43.** Schedule friendship. Do not rely on 'we should catch up'.

[ ] **44.** Be a man others can confide in, and confide in someone yourself

[ ] **45.** Do not make your partner your only emotional lifeline

[ ] **46.** Show up when a friend is in trouble

[ ] **47.** Check on the friend who goes quiet

[ ] **48.** Join something bigger than yourself

[ ] **49.** Build relationships across generations

[ ] **50.** Prefer a few deep friendships over many shallow ones

6. Fatherhood and Family

[ ] **51.** Be present. Showing up is the job.

[ ] **52.** Engage directly: play, read, talk, listen

[ ] **53.** Respect the child's mother, whatever the status of your relationship

[ ] **54.** Discipline with calm and consistency, never with rage

[ ] **55.** Listen more than you lecture

[ ] **56.** Model the man you want your children to become

[ ] **57.** Teach emotional skills to your sons, and respect to everyone

[ ] **58.** Share the load of raising children, and of running the home

[ ] **59.** If you live apart from your children, stay involved anyway

[ ] **60.** Honour your parents and care for them as they age

7. Money

[ ] **61.** Spend less than you earn, always

[ ] **62.** Pay yourself first: save 10 to 20 percent of income

[ ] **63.** Build an emergency fund before you do anything fancy

[ ] **64.** Pay off high-interest debt as an investment

[ ] **65.** Invest in low-cost, broad index funds

[ ] **66.** Watch the fees. They compound against you.

[ ] **67.** Start early. Time does more than talent.

[ ] **68.** Insure against catastrophe, not against inconvenience

[ ] **69.** Never chase get-rich-quick schemes or invest in what you do not understand

[ ] **70.** Talk about money openly with your partner, and keep records

8. Work and Skill

[ ] **71.** Master a craft

[ ] **72.** Never stop learning

[ ] **73.** Be reliable. Finish what you start.

[ ] **74.** Learn to communicate clearly, in writing and speech

[ ] **75.** Seek feedback and take it seriously

[ ] **76.** Know your market value and negotiate

[ ] **77.** Build your network before you need it

[ ] **78.** Do not let your job destroy your health or your family

[ ] **79.** Do not let your job become your whole identity

[ ] **80.** Give credit generously and take blame honestly

9. Discipline and Habits

[ ] **81.** Build systems, not just motivation

[ ] **82.** Give a new habit at least two months, and expect it to take longer

[ ] **83.** Start small enough that you cannot fail

[ ] **84.** Do the hardest or most important thing first
[ ] **85.** Run a weekly review
[ ] **86.** Learn to say no
[ ] **87.** Shape your environment so that good choices are easy
[ ] **88.** Keep the promises you make to yourself
[ ] **89.** Rest deliberately. Recovery is part of discipline.
[ ] **90.** When you fall off, restart immediately without drama

10. Conduct and Legacy

[ ] **91.** Do not take stupid physical risks
[ ] **92.** Learn first aid and basic emergency skills
[ ] **93.** Be self-reliant: cook, clean, repair, manage your own affairs
[ ] **94.** Take care of your appearance and your surroundings
[ ] **95.** Listen more than you speak
[ ] **96.** Do not complain without offering a solution
[ ] **97.** Stand up for others. Do not tolerate cruelty.
[ ] **98.** Be generous with your time, attention and money
[ ] **99.** Prepare for the worst: will, documents and a plan for your family
[ ] **100.** Review your life every year, and invest in the people who matter

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